constructing a fountain.[26] But none of these appear to be royal buildings. This is disappointing to those interested in visualizing the world of royalty on the ground, especially since several medieval palace complexes, from those of the Vijayanagara rulers at Hampi to the Mughal palaces of Agra and Delhi, are well known and have survived. The residences and administrative blocks of ancient Indian city rulers have generally been more elusive. Even in the Mauryan city of Taxila, which has been extensively excavated, we see dwelling houses and structures along the streets and lanes, but the buildings of the elite tend to go missing; and this is true for other Mauryan cities as well.

An important reason for the problem in relation to Pataliputra is that much of what we know about it does not, in fact, come from the centre of the ancient city, where the palace was likely to be located, but from what has emerged of the edges and outskirts of the old town, where controlled excavations have been possible. Since fortifications were usually put up on a settlement's boundaries, the remains of the wooden palisade which protected Pataliputra have been revealed. This was an element of the urban landscape vividly described by Megasthenes. Uprights of strong timber that have been found in excavations in various parts of present-day Patna make it clear that his description was, in this case, based on what he actually saw. These defences were made of two parallel rows of walls constituted by wooden posts about 4.5 m. high, paved with wooden sleepers, and covered above with wooden planks. This was likely to have been a tunnel-like passage. It was one that was covered with earth up to a certain height on its exterior.[27] We also know that the city's drains, which discharged waste water outside the city, were made of wood. Such details about drains and palisades are a consequence of numerous digs in the area of Bulandibagh in Patna, a locality once dominated by a fruit garden—thus allowing enough space to excavate.